

“IT DOESN'T MATTER HOW WE'RE PLAYING. IF WE DON'T WIN, THEY'RE NOT HAPPY. THE MOST IMPORTANT THING IS TO WIN”

— JOSE MOLINA

slipping away in the second half, Molina and Bagan leaned on their storied history, star quality, and their expectant fanbase to pull through.

Watching Mohun Bagan chase a game at the spiritual home of Indian football – Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata – is an experience beyond words. Systems and formations fall by the wayside as the game is driven by the crowd.

With every tackle flying across the pitch and passes fired into the opposition box from all directions, the noise inside builds, inching toward a crescendo. Just as chaos seems inevitable, Mohun Bagan rises; the football and the supporters form a powerful synergy amid the madness. It wasn't 'total football', but it was substance over style.

While opposition players wilt under the pressure, Bagan thrives. It has been here before, and it knows exactly what to do – its dominance at home this season has been undeniable. There was only one likely outcome.

Jamshedpur FC painfully discovered this in the second semifinal leg, and 10 other teams had similar experiences in Kolkata during the league stage. Bengaluru was no different in the final.

To its credit, Bengaluru kept the cauldron under control, suppressing the atmosphere with possession and forcing Bagan into its own half. The pressure paid off when an own goal gave the visitor a deserved lead against the league's most defensively sound team.

Bagan played like a jazz band in revolt — no sheet music, no conductor, just pure instinct. Formations blurred, structure

Captivating scenes: Watching Mohun Bagan chase a game at the spiritual home of Indian football – Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata – is an experience beyond words. PICS: FSDL

dissolved, and the tempo surged. Bengaluru's defence couldn't keep pace. A single error, and Jason Cummings pounced to equalise.

As the game wore on, the difference in squad depth proved decisive. Last season, when Bagan faltered at the final hurdle, its bench options were limited. Sahal Abdul Samad and Kiyan Nassiri were the only substitutes used during the 90 minutes.

The club ensured this season would be different. When Bagan needed to turn up the tempo, it had two India internationals (Sahal and Ashique Kuruniyan) and two former ISL Golden Ball winners (Greg Stewart and Dimitrios Petratos) to call on.

In extra time, Jamie Maclaren, another overseas international, who had scored on six separate occasions in the league to give Bagan the lead, delivered the knockout blow.

It was another smash-and-grab moment. Just as NorthEast United, Chennaiyin FC, Kerala Blasters, Jamshedpur, and others had found out, Rahul Bheke failed to clear his lines, and Maclaren pounced to deliver the dagger.

How he gets the job done may not please everyone, but Molina had once again orchestrated another famous night for India's biggest club.

"Money is important," admitted Molina, "but it's not the only thing." As the dust settled on the season, the records would speak for themselves. Along with the most wins, most points, most goals scored, least goals conceded, and an unbeaten home record, Molina became only the second coach in the league's history to complete the Shield and Cup double.

With another trophy in hand, Molina, in his own way, was able to settle scores off the pitch too, particularly taking aim at Chennaiyin FC boss Owen Coyle's remarks. The Scotsman had claimed he would win titles every season with Bagan's budget.

"I think it's a lack of respect to the other coach who is doing his job and trying his best. Everybody has their style. He can continue saying things, I'll continue working and try to win titles," Molina snapped back.

With a mic-drop moment, Molina, fittingly, had the last word.

